

AMERICAN HISTORY

A Comprehensive Study Guide

From the first Native American civilizations through the founding of a nation built on revolutionary ideals, to the Civil War, world wars, civil rights movements, and into the modern era - this guide covers the essential events, figures, and themes that shaped the United States of America.

CONTENTS	
1. Pre-Colonial America	3
2. Colonial Era (1607-1776)	4
3. Revolutionary War & Founding	5
4. Early Republic & Expansion	6
5. Civil War & Reconstruction	7
6. Gilded Age & Progressive Era	8
7. World Wars Era	9
8. Cold War & Civil Rights	10
9. Modern America	11
10. Key Terms & Review	12

1. PRE-COLONIAL AMERICA

Native American Civilizations

Before European contact, North America was home to diverse and sophisticated Native American civilizations with rich cultures, complex social structures, and advanced agricultural practices.

Region	Major Tribes	Key Characteristics
Northeast	Iroquois, Algonquin	Longhouses, democratic confederacy
Southeast	Cherokee, Creek, Seminole	Advanced agriculture, mound builders
Plains	Sioux, Cheyenne, Comanche	Nomadic, buffalo hunting
Southwest	Navajo, Apache, Pueblo	Adobe dwellings, irrigation farming
Pacific NW	Chinook, Tlingit	Fishing, totem poles, potlatch

Key Facts to Remember:

- Population estimates: 2-18 million Native Americans lived in North America pre-contact
- The Iroquois Confederacy influenced the U.S. Constitution's federal structure
- European diseases would eventually kill 90% of the native population

2. COLONIAL ERA (1607-1776)

The Thirteen Colonies

Colony Type	Colonies	Economy & Character
New England	MA, CT, RI, NH	Fishing, shipbuilding, religious (Puritan)
Middle	NY, NJ, PA, DE	Diverse, farming, trade, tolerant
Southern	MD, VA, NC, SC, GA	Plantation agriculture, slavery, aristocratic

Major Colonial Events Timeline:

1607	Jamestown established - first permanent English settlement
1619	First enslaved Africans arrive in Virginia; House of Burgesses formed
1620	Mayflower Compact signed by Pilgrims at Plymouth
1692	Salem Witch Trials in Massachusetts
1754-1763	French and Indian War - Britain gains Canada
1765	Stamp Act sparks colonial resistance
1770	Boston Massacre - 5 colonists killed
1773	Boston Tea Party - protest against taxation
1774	First Continental Congress meets

3. REVOLUTIONARY WAR & FOUNDING

Causes of the Revolution

- **Taxation without representation** - Stamp Act, Townshend Acts, Tea Act
- **Intolerable Acts (1774)** - Punitive laws after Boston Tea Party
- **Enlightenment ideas** - Natural rights, social contract (Locke, Montesquieu)
- **Colonial unity** - Committees of Correspondence, Continental Congress

Key Figures

Figure	Role	Significance
George Washington	Commander-in-Chief	Led Continental Army, 1st President
Thomas Jefferson	Author	Wrote Declaration of Independence
Benjamin Franklin	Diplomat	Secured French alliance
John Adams	Diplomat/Lawyer	Advocated independence, 2nd President
Alexander Hamilton	Aide-de-camp	Financial architect of new nation

Major Battles

Battle	Date	Significance
Lexington & Concord	April 1775	"Shot heard round the world" - war begins
Bunker Hill	June 1775	Proved colonists could fight British regulars
Trenton	Dec 1776	Washington crosses Delaware, boosts morale
Saratoga	Oct 1777	Turning point - France enters war
Yorktown	Oct 1781	Final major battle - British surrender

4. EARLY REPUBLIC & EXPANSION

Creating the Constitution (1787)

After the weak Articles of Confederation failed, delegates met in Philadelphia to create a stronger federal government with checks and balances.

Branch	Powers	Checks
Legislative (Congress)	Makes laws, declares war, taxes	Presidential veto, judicial review
Executive (President)	Enforces laws, commands military	Congressional override, impeachment
Judicial (Courts)	Interprets laws, judicial review	Appointment by President/Senate

Westward Expansion

1803	Louisiana Purchase	Doubled US size, \$15 million from France
1804-1806	Lewis & Clark Expedition	Explored western territories
1823	Monroe Doctrine	Warned Europe against Western Hemisphere colonization
1830	Indian Removal Act	Forced relocation - Trail of Tears
1845	Texas Annexation	Former Mexican territory joins US
1846-1848	Mexican-American War	US gains California, Southwest
1848	California Gold Rush	Massive westward migration begins

5. CIVIL WAR & RECONSTRUCTION

Causes of the Civil War

- **Slavery** - Fundamental moral and economic divide
- **States' Rights** - Federal vs. state authority debate
- **Economic differences** - Industrial North vs. Agricultural South
- **Compromises failing** - Missouri Compromise, Kansas-Nebraska Act, Dred Scott

Union vs. Confederacy

Factor	Union (North)	Confederacy (South)
Population	22 million	9 million (3.5M enslaved)
Industry	90% of factories	10% of factories
Railroads	70% of rail miles	30% of rail miles
Strategy	Anaconda Plan - blockade	Defensive war, foreign aid
Leaders	Lincoln, Grant, Sherman	Davis, Lee, Jackson

Key Events & Turning Points

April 1861	Fort Sumter	War begins - Confederates fire first shots
Sept 1862	Antietam	Bloodiest single day; leads to Emancipation
Jan 1863	Emancipation Proclamation	Freed slaves in Confederate states
July 1863	Gettysburg	Turning point - Lee defeated in North
April 1865	Lee's Surrender	Appomattox Court House - war ends
April 1865	Lincoln's Assassination	John Wilkes Booth kills Lincoln

Reconstruction Amendments

13th Amendment (1865)	Abolished slavery
14th Amendment (1868)	Citizenship, equal protection, due process
15th Amendment (1870)	Voting rights regardless of race

6. GILDED AGE & PROGRESSIVE ERA

The Gilded Age (1870s-1900)

A period of rapid industrialization, massive immigration, and growing inequality. The term 'Gilded Age' suggests a thin gold coating over base metal - glittering on the surface but corrupt underneath.

Robber Barons	Industry	Practices
John D. Rockefeller	Oil (Standard Oil)	Horizontal integration, trusts
Andrew Carnegie	Steel	Vertical integration
J.P. Morgan	Banking/Railroads	Financial consolidation
Cornelius Vanderbilt	Railroads/Shipping	Railroad empire

Progressive Era Reforms (1890s-1920)

- **Trust-busting** - Sherman Antitrust Act, breaking up monopolies
- **Labor reforms** - Child labor laws, workplace safety
- **Political reforms** - Direct election of senators (17th), women's suffrage (19th)
- **Social reforms** - Settlement houses, prohibition (18th Amendment)

7. WORLD WARS ERA

World War I (1914-1918)

The US entered in 1917 after German submarine warfare and the Zimmermann Telegram. Over 116,000 Americans died.

Cause for US Entry	Unrestricted submarine warfare, Zimmermann Telegram
US Role	Provided fresh troops, supplies, boosted Allied morale
Home Front	Liberty Bonds, Espionage Act, women in workforce
Result	Treaty of Versailles (1919), League of Nations (US did not join)

The Roaring Twenties & Great Depression

- **1920s Prosperity** - Jazz Age, consumer culture, stock speculation
- **1929 Crash** - Black Tuesday triggers Great Depression
- **New Deal (1933-1939)** - FDR's programs: Social Security, FDIC, SEC, WPA

World War II (1939-1945)

Dec 7, 1941	Pearl Harbor	Japan attacks; US enters war
June 6, 1944	D-Day	Allied invasion of Normandy
Aug 1945	Atomic Bombs	Hiroshima & Nagasaki; Japan surrenders

8. COLD WAR & CIVIL RIGHTS

The Cold War (1947-1991)

Ideological conflict between US (capitalism/democracy) and USSR (communism) without direct military confrontation.

Event	Date	Significance
Truman Doctrine	1947	US policy to contain communism
Marshall Plan	1948	Economic aid to rebuild Europe
Korean War	1950-1953	First hot war of Cold War era
Cuban Missile Crisis	1962	Closest to nuclear war
Vietnam War	1955-1975	58,000 Americans killed; divisive at home
Fall of Berlin Wall	1989	Cold War effectively ends
USSR Collapse	1991	Cold War officially over

Civil Rights Movement (1954-1968)

1954	Brown v. Board of Education	School segregation unconstitutional
1955	Montgomery Bus Boycott	Rosa Parks; MLK emerges as leader
1963	March on Washington	"I Have a Dream" speech
1964	Civil Rights Act	Banned discrimination in public places
1965	Voting Rights Act	Protected voting rights
1968	MLK Assassination	Fair Housing Act passed

9. MODERN AMERICA (1970s-Present)

Era	Key Events	Significance
1970s	Watergate, Oil Crisis	Trust in government declines
1980s	Reagan Revolution	Conservative resurgence, Cold War ends
1990s	Tech Boom, Clinton Era	Economic prosperity, globalization
2001	9/11 Attacks	War on Terror begins
2008	Financial Crisis	Great Recession, Obama elected
2010s	ACA, Social Media Era	Political polarization increases
2020	COVID-19 Pandemic	Global health crisis, economic disruption

10. KEY TERMS & REVIEW

Term	Definition
Manifest Destiny	Belief that US expansion across North America was inevitable and justified
Federalism	Division of power between federal and state governments
Checks and Balances	Each branch of government can limit the others
Judicial Review	Supreme Court can declare laws unconstitutional (Marbury v. Madison)
Isolationism	Policy of avoiding involvement in foreign affairs
Containment	Cold War strategy to prevent spread of communism
Jim Crow Laws	State laws enforcing racial segregation in the South
Suffrage	The right to vote
Imperialism	Policy of extending power through colonization or military force
Progressivism	Reform movement addressing industrialization problems

Quick Review - Important Documents

Document	Year	Significance
Declaration of Independence	1776	Declared independence from Britain
Constitution	1787	Established framework of US government
Bill of Rights	1791	First 10 amendments - individual rights
Emancipation Proclamation	1863	Freed slaves in Confederate states
Gettysburg Address	1863	Redefined the purpose of the war